

news feed

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hypothesis

Wireless USB

■ What is it?

A technology that allows wireless connectivity between your PC and peripherals, and even other PCs, using radio waves.

■ How does it work?

It works on radio frequency in the 2.4 GHz spectrum. Using chips developed by Cypress Semiconductor, several devices can be connected simultaneously, but the latency increases with the number of devices. Devices will work as far away as 10 meters, and since it works on radio, line-of-sight is not required.

■ Why should I use it?

The main advantage WUSB has over Bluetooth is that USB support is already universal among operating systems, whilst Bluetooth support is still shaky. Current USB keyboards and other human interface devices will not require new drivers. Another major benefit is low cost and low power requirements.

snapshot

The world-wide market for **anti-virus** software should reach **\$4.4 billion** in **2007**, up from **\$2.2 billion** in **2002**

Source: IDC

Pricey penguin

Research firm Gartner, has concluded that migrating to Linux makes business sense, only in very few situations. Whilst Linux costs next to nothing, the total cost of ownership is quite high. A move to Linux means that replacements will be required for all the desktop

packages a person uses. Linux scores high marks in the server area, where typically servers run only one application. It can also be cost-effective on the desktop when used for simple

ILLUSTRATOR: Farzana Cooper



tasks such as data entry. The findings also reveal that it is beneficial for companies currently running Windows 95 to migrate to Linux considering the high costs of maintaining the older OS—now that Microsoft has stopped supporting it.

Consumers want truth in advertising

A lawsuit has been filed against Apple, Dell, Gateway, HP, IBM, Sharp and Sony by a group of computer owners, saying that the advertisements overstate the capacity of their hard drives—for example, what is described as a 20 GB hard drive, actually has a capacity of 18.6 GB. This happens because computers follow the binary system, but to mention the capacity, manufacturers use decimal notation. The result is that if consumers buy a 150 GB hard drive, they actually get 140 GB.

The lawsuit asks the defendants to disclose their unfair marketing practices to the public, and distribute the profits made by this ill-practice.

The other confusion area is the speed of the Internet connections where 56 Kbps actually means 56 Kilo bits per second, whereas most people think it's 56 Kilo bytes per second.

Now, they can tap your calls

An Israeli scientist, Elad Barkan, and his team have found a flaw in the Global System for Mobile communications (GSM) code that allows you to break into mobile phone calls, and even take over the caller's identity.

According to Barkan, the GSM code gives high priority to call quality and noise interference correction after which it encrypts the call. This enabled the

researchers to break into the call.

The GSM Association said that they knew about this vulnerability, and had even released a patch in July 2002 to fix the encryption algorithm. However, the researchers claimed they also managed to overcome the new encryption system that was put in place as a response to previous attacks.



Lindows settles Microsoft for you

Lindows has announced a new service that will help you get your share of the \$1.1 billion Microsoft settlement for overcharging Windows users. The ruling applies to consumers who bought Microsoft software in California, between February 1995 and December 2001. Depending on the software they bought, they will receive vouchers. The catch here is that the vouchers can only be used to buy Lindows software. The Web site—



www.MSFreePC.com—will handle the process of making legal claims, and will even give 10,000 plaintiffs free PCs. Consumers have till March 2004, and just need to fill out the forms available on the Web site. If they meet the criteria, they can get some software from Lindows.com, including a Windows version of StarOffice.

■ Ford moves its IT infrastructure for sales and human resources to Linux ■ BSNI, MTNL, VSNL, and Dishnet do not meet TRAI's quality norms